different from in the United States. This does not mean, of course, that anti-black racism did not, and does not still, exist in Cuba. No society whose history is based on centuries of racially-based exploitation can free itself overnight from the structures and ideas built into this kind of system. Even within the independence movement some, like Céspedes, argued for a gradual abolition that would accommodate the interests of the sugar plantocracy. Still, the relationship of anti-black racism to nationalism, and the relationships of blacks to the independence movement and ideology, were very different in Cuba from in the United States. After 1902, nationalist ideas about the integral connection between foreign, colonial domination and racial inequality only strengthened.

The experience and meaning of independence in Cuba were also shaped by the role of the United States in the process. Cuba fought for and obtained independence in a continent that was increasingly dominated by its northern neighbor. Martí echoed the sentiment of Simón Bolívar, leader of the Latin American independence movements three-quarters of a century earlier, who famously stated that "The United States … seem[s] destined by Providence to plague America with torments in the name of freedom."[7] In 1823 the Monroe Doctrine announced U.S. intentions to police the hemisphere (for its own good, of course). The United States extended its control westward, challenging newly independent Mexico and climaxing in a war that added over half of Mexico's territory to the United States in 1848. In 1891, Martí penned the similarly oft-quoted essay "Our America" in which he warned of the U.S. threat. He used the phrase "Our America" to refer to Latin America, which he contrasted to the other America – the United States.

"Our America is running another risk that does not come from itself but from the difference in origins, methods, and interest between the two halves of the continent … The scorn of our formidable neighbor, who does not know us, is Our America's greatest danger … Through ignorance it may even come to lay hands on us …" To challenge the threat of U.S. domination, Martí argued, Latin America must embrace its non-European origins – the very origins that the United States rejected. Latin America must "make common cause with the oppressed, in order